Kai Wu

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Education

The University of Texas at Austin, Ph.D. in Economics — Aug. 2021 – Present
Jinan University, M.A. in Economics — Sept. 2018 – Jun. 2021
Northwest University (China), B.A. in Economics — Sept. 2014 – Jun. 2018

Research Fields

Public Economics, Networks, Macroeconomics, Environmental Economics, Urban Economics

References

Marika Cabral (Primary)
Department of Economics
UT Austin
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Nitya Pandalai-Nayar
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Jackson Dorsey
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Cody Tuttle
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Working Papers

Beyond Targeted Firms: Supply Chain Spillovers of Environmental Regulation in China [Job Market Paper] (draft available upon request)

Crowding (with Yizhen Gu, Qu Tang, and Ben Zou)

Abstract: Crowding is a common disamenity, yet little is known about its monetary cost. We estimate the willingness to pay (WTP) to avoid crowding in public transit with a revealed-preference approach. Beijing Subway passengers choose departure times, trading off fare, in-train crowding, and schedule deviation, with price variation from an early-bird discount. Leveraging the subway's network structure, we impute real-time in-train crowding, infer each passenger's optimal arrival time, and construct a novel instrumental variable for crowding. The marginal WTP to reduce crowding by one passenger per square meter is about 0.05 RMB per minute, implying a crowding externality exceeding the fare. High-income passengers have higher crowding WTP but are less price-sensitive. An optimal crowding tax improves welfare but is regressive; a two-class configuration elicits self-selection and benefits both high and low income commuters.

Political Consolidation and Corporate Tax Burden

Selected Work in Progress

Stock Market Turbulence and Production Networks (with Husang Kim and Rikuto Onishi)
Research question: Does non-fundamental stock price volatility propagate through production networks?

Conference and Seminar Presentations

(* indicates scheduled) UT Austin; ABFER Annual Conference*; SMU Trade Conference*; SEA Annual Meeting* (nominated student)	2026
Texas Applied Microeconomics Student Workshop	2025

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, The University of Texas at Austin

Introduction to Microeconomics	2021, 2022, 2024, 2026
Urban Economics	2022
Business Strategy	2023
Industrial Organization	2023
Economics of Education	2025
Energy and Environmental Economics	2025

Research Experience

Research Assistant for Prof. Yizhen Gu	2018–2021
Research Assistant for Prof. Marika Cabral	2023–2025

Skills

Software: Stata, Python, R, ArcGIS, QGIS, LaTeX
Languages: English (fluent), Chinese (native)